PART IV · HARMONY · 10

Cadences

A phrase is a musical sentence, and it needs punctuation. The last two chords of a phrase are its **cadence**. They tell you: finished, taking a breath, or surprise!

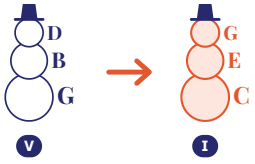
THE SECRET

Music has full stops and commas too: listen to the last two chords of a phrase.

.

Perfect

V → I

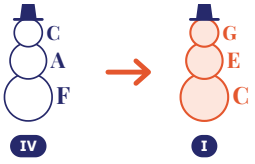


Home. The end.

Amen

Plagal

IV → I

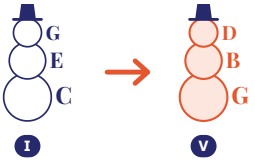


A soft, gentle end.

,

Imperfect

… → V

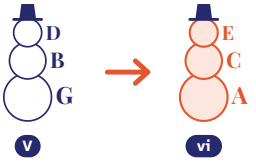


To be continued…

?!

Interrupted

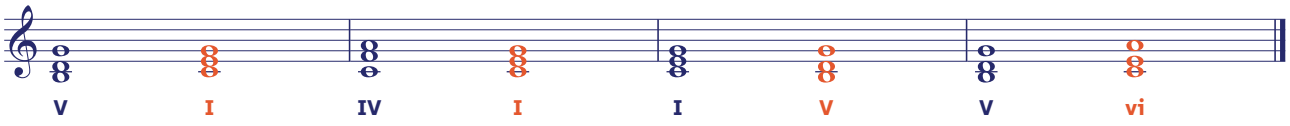
V → vi



Surprise! Not home.

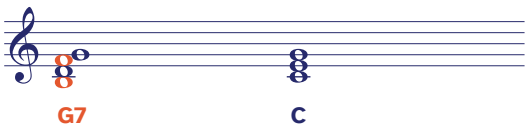
1. Find the end of a phrase: often a long note, or a breath.
2. Name its **last two chords** with numerals: V I, IV I, anything then V, or V vi.
3. Match the punctuation: full stop (.), Amen, comma (,) or ?!

The four cadences in C



Perfect, plagal, imperfect, interrupted. The red chord is where each one lands.

CADENCE	CHORDS	FEELS LIKE	ALSO CALLED
Perfect	V → I	a full stop: finished	authentic, full close
Plagal	IV → I	the “A-men” sung at the end of a song in church	Amen cadence
Imperfect	any → V	a comma: waiting	half close, half cadence
Interrupted	V → vi	a surprise: not home yet	deceptive

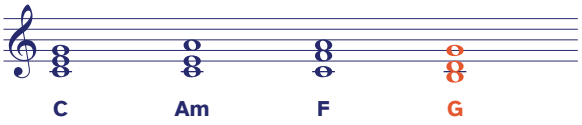


Make the full stop stronger: add the 7th to V. In G7 the **F** falls to E and the **B** rises to C: two small steps home (Seventh chords, p. 76).

PART IV · HARMONY · 10 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE

How does this phrase end? C Am F G

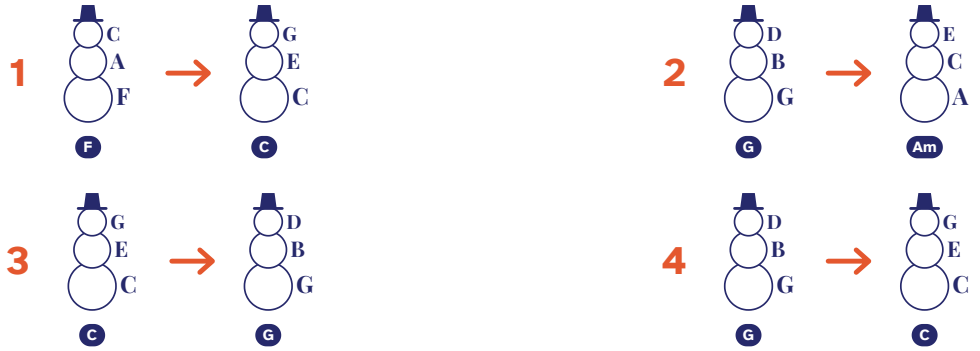


1. **The last two chords:** F, then G.
2. **As numerals:** IV, then V.
3. **It lands on V:** the comma.

An **imperfect cadence**: the music takes a breath, and the next phrase answers it.

GAME

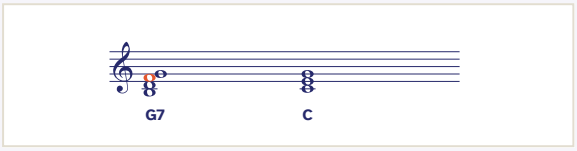
Punctuate the phrases



Each pair ends a phrase in C major. Turn the letters into numerals first (C is I, F is IV, G is V, Am is vi), then write full stop, comma, Amen or ?! beside each.

Answer: 1 Amen (plagal), 2 ?! (interrupted), 3 comma (imperfect), 4 full stop (perfect).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Play G7, then C. The end!

Now play G7, then A minor: “huh?!” That is the interrupted cadence. Then play F, then C, and sing “A-men”.

THINK OF IT Punctuation in a sentence: a full stop ends it, a comma makes you wait, and a surprise makes you gasp. Music ends its phrases the same way.

TRAP

- × Calling every ending on I (C) perfect: a perfect cadence comes **from V**. F to C is plagal.
- × Mixing up imperfect and perfect: imperfect **ends on** V; perfect **starts on** V and lands on I.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 72 · Seventh chords p. 76 · Chords under a melody p. 89

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 10 · Online: Library › Cadences